

Stake Holder Engagement

African Folktales Small Language Model (SLM)

From Stakeholder Mapping to Meaningful Engagement

This plan builds on our stakeholder mapping (using Wakunuma and Jiya's method) for the African Folktales SLM. It moves from analysis to action by selecting two priority stakeholder groups, articulating what matters most to them, identifying the harms and benefits at stake, and matching each group to a concrete engagement method drawn from the Action Catalogue. It closes by tracing how these engagement methods would concretely reshape our dataset and model design.

1. Selected Stakeholder Groups

Drawing on our stakeholder map, we focus this plan on two groups whose involvement is most consequential for whether the SLM preserves or erodes the traditions it is meant to serve:

- Community Elders and Traditional Storykeepers — the knowledge holders and rights-bearers of the oral material itself.
- Diaspora Parents and Cultural Associations — the intended primary beneficiaries, seeking authentic cultural connection for children raised outside their ancestral communities.

2. What Matters Most to Each Group

Community Elders and Traditional Storykeepers care most about respect for their intellectual property and control over how their stories are used once digitized. They want accurate attribution to their specific community, language, and region, and they fear flattening of narrative nuance into a generic “pan-African” voice, or extraction without ongoing consent. Diaspora Parents and Cultural Associations care most about authenticity and trustworthiness: they want stories that are correctly sourced, paired with cultural context and moral meaning, and able to strengthen a child's sense of belonging rather than offering a homogenized substitute. Both groups want assurance that the technology serves communities rather than extracting from them, and that it deepens rather than replaces relationships with living storytellers.

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3. Potential Harms and Benefits

Community Elders and Traditional Storykeepers

Potential harms: misattribution of a story to the wrong ethnolinguistic group, functioning as a form of erasure; loss of control once oral material is translated or paraphrased by the model; and community IP

being treated as free-for-use “public domain” data. Potential benefits: formal recognition and named attribution of their community's contribution; a structured channel for their knowledge to reach diaspora youth at scale; and strengthened intergenerational transmission if the tool is positioned as a bridge to elders rather than a replacement for them.

Diaspora Parents and Cultural Associations

Potential harms: exposure to homogenized or inaccurate “generic African folklore” that fails to reflect a family's specific heritage, and a risk that easy digital access reduces motivation to seek out real storykeepers or community events. Potential benefits: searchable, translated access to stories tied to a named lineage; culturally resonant educational material for children growing up far from ancestral communities; and stronger, more confident engagement with heritage that could increase, rather than replace, contact with community elders and cultural events.

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4. Engagement Methods (via the Action Catalogue)

Using the Action Catalogue (actioncatalogue.eu) as a decision-support tool, we matched each stakeholder group to a method suited to their context, digital access, and relationship to the material:

- Community Elders and Traditional Storykeepers → Standing User Committee (a form of ongoing distributed dialogue).
- Diaspora Parents and Cultural Associations → Participatory Design Workshops.

5. Why Each Method Fits

Community Elders and Traditional Storykeepers: Standing User Committee

We propose establishing a Standing User Committee composed of elders, traditional storykeepers, and community-nominated cultural custodians, convened on a recurring basis for the life of the project rather than as a one-off consultation. This method fits the Community Elders and Storykeepers group for several interlocking reasons rooted in both the project's own documentation and the realities of the communities involved.

First, our Data Card already commits to a human-in-the-loop review system in which “community councils” resolve disagreements between annotators to guarantee cultural authenticity and linguistic accuracy. A Standing User Committee is the natural institutional home for that commitment: rather than an abstract council invoked only when disputes arise, it gives elders a persistent seat with real authority over labeling, attribution, and dataset inclusion decisions. This converts a paper commitment into a functioning governance structure.

Second, our Impact Statement explicitly names the need for “a standing review process rather than a one-time approval” and flags that we do not yet have a complete answer for how attribution holds up once a story has been paraphrased or translated by the model. A single consultation, focus group, or survey could capture initial preferences, but it cannot catch the kind of drift that emerges only after the model is in use — subtle changes in tone, moral framing, or regional detail that accumulate over successive translations. A standing committee that reviews sampled outputs on an ongoing basis is structurally suited to catching this drift early, before it compounds into the kind of homogenization the Impact Statement warns against.

Third, this method respects the specific relationship elders have to the material. Storykeepers are not generic “users” providing feedback on a product; they are rights-holders whose oral heritage is the model's core input. A standing committee signals that their role is governance and ongoing consent, not one-time data donation. This aligns directly with our stated value of “respect for indigenous intellectual property” and the consent-first pipeline described in the Data Card, which treats oral histories as belonging to source communities rather than being extractable once collected.

Fourth, a recurring committee structure is realistic given the digital-access constraints named in our own Bias and Representation analysis. Many elders and storykeepers are based in communities with limited internet access. A standing committee can be convened through community radio networks, local partner NGOs, and periodic in-person or offline sessions — channels we have already committed to for offline oral data collection — rather than requiring elders to participate in a purely digital, one-time survey instrument that would exclude the very voices we most need to protect from erasure.

Finally, a Standing User Committee gives elders veto-like influence over sensitive decisions: what counts as an acceptable translation, whether a synthetic back-translated passage preserves meaning, and how a story should be tagged by region and ethnolinguistic group. This directly mitigates the misattribution risk identified in Step 3, because the people most able to detect a misattribution — the community's own knowledge holders — are structurally positioned to catch it before publication, not after.

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Diaspora Parents and Cultural Associations: Participatory Design Workshops

For Diaspora Parents and Cultural Associations, we propose a series of Participatory Design Workshops, run collaboratively with parents, diaspora cultural associations, and children where age-appropriate, to co-design how the model presents, translates, and contextualizes stories before the interface and output formats are finalized.

This method fits the group's situation for several reasons. First, diaspora families are the primary intended beneficiaries of the tool but were not the source of the underlying oral material, so their most valuable contribution is not raw data but judgment about usability, trust, and cultural resonance — exactly what Participatory Design is built to elicit. Unlike a one-way survey, participatory design invites parents and cultural associations to sit alongside the design team and shape concrete artifacts: sample story outputs,

translation formats, glossary explanations of unfamiliar terms, and the moral-lesson framing that accompanies each tale. This produces actionable design decisions rather than abstract sentiment.

Second, our Impact Statement raises a specific, unresolved risk: that easy digital access could “quietly substitute for the relationship it's supposed to support” between diaspora children and real storykeepers. This is precisely the kind of risk that a workshop format can surface and address at the design stage, because parents and cultural associations can react directly to prototype features — for example, whether the interface actively points users toward community events, elder-led sessions, or cultural associations rather than presenting itself as a self-sufficient substitute. A generic feedback form is unlikely to surface this concern with the same clarity as watching parents interact with an actual prototype and voice discomfort in real time.

Third, diaspora communities are heterogeneous: a Yoruba family in London and a Zulu family in Toronto have different language needs, different levels of fluency in ancestral languages, and different expectations about how much English or French scaffolding a translation should include. Workshops allow this variation to surface directly through iterative co-design across multiple diaspora communities, rather than assuming a single “diaspora user” persona, which would risk exactly the homogenization the project is trying to avoid.

Fourth, Participatory Design Workshops are logistically well suited to this group's context. Unlike elders in low-connectivity settings, diaspora families are typically reachable through cultural associations, community centers, and diaspora organizations already active online and in person in host countries, making structured multi-session workshops feasible without the offline infrastructure required for the elders' committee.

Finally, this method operationalizes our stated value of transparency. By co-designing how data origin and cultural attribution are displayed to end-users — for instance, how a story visibly names its Yoruba or Zulu origin rather than presenting as unattributed “African folklore” — diaspora parents and cultural associations directly shape the interface feature most responsible for preventing the “flattened pan-African bucket” outcome our Impact Statement warns against, while also building the trust needed for the tool to be adopted at all.

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6. How These Methods Would Shape the Dataset and Model

The Standing User Committee would give elders direct, recurring authority to flag misattributed or drifted content, adjust regional and ethnolinguistic tagging, and refine consent scope as new sources are added — turning our labeling and consent processes from static rules into a living, community-audited system. The Participatory Design Workshops would shape output design: prompting us to add explicit origin-attribution displays, adjustable translation depth, glossary support for unfamiliar terms, and built-in

prompts connecting users to real storykeepers and cultural events, so the model complements rather than substitutes for living community relationships.

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Note on sourcing

This plan draws directly on the project's own Problem Statement, Data Card, and Impact Statement, and applies the Action Catalogue framework referenced in the assignment brief to select methods suited to each group's context and constraints.